The Lie Economy Inventory

Thirty-seven statements. Answer them the way things actually are, not the way you have described them to your boss.

This is not a personality test. It is not a development tool designed to make you feel good about your "growth areas."

Answer with brutal honesty. Not how you wish things were. How they **actually are**. If you find yourself rationalizing, qualifying, or adding "but" to your answer — that is The Will talking. Pay attention to it.

This inventory is a mirror.

> **BEFORE YOU BEGIN**
>
> Do not take this alone. Take it, then ask your people to take it *about you*. Then compare. If there is a significant gap between how you scored yourself and how they scored you, that gap is your Lie Economy — the distance between the story you are telling yourself and the truth.

SCORE EACH STATEMENT

1	This is absolutely true in my organization
2	This is mostly true
3	This is sometimes true
4	This is rarely true
5	This is not true at all

1 MARK

Tick one box per statement. Work quickly — your first answer is usually the honest one.

2 SUBTOTAL

Add each pillar at the foot of its section. Carry the five subtotals to the scoring page.

3 COMPARE

Print a second copy for your people. The gap between their total and yours is the real finding.

1 Important Work

Do people believe the work matters?

	ABSOLUTELY TRUE 1 2 3 4 5 NOT TRUE AT ALL					
01	I have assigned my team to work on projects that I knew were not important because we needed to look like we were doing something.	1	2	3	4	5
02	I have sold unimportant work to my team as critical or transformational when I knew it was neither.	1	2	3	4	5
03	My team is currently working on something that exists primarily to make my department look valuable, not because it solves a real problem.	1	2	3	4	5
04	I have created teams or initiatives that were designed to produce a deliverable rather than to solve a root-cause problem.	1	2	3	4	5
05	If I asked my team - honestly and without consequence - whether they believe the work they are doing is important, I would not like the answer.	1	2	3	4	5
06	I have continued a project or initiative that I knew was failing because admitting failure would make me or my department look bad.	1	2	3	4	5
07	I have stripped autonomy from a team by predetermining the solution and asking them to execute rather than solve.	1	2	3	4	5
08	When my team has told me the work is not important or the approach won't work, I have dismissed or ignored their input.	1	2	3	4	5

IMPORTANT WORK SUBTOTAL _____ / 40

2 Curiosity

Can people ask why?

	ABSOLUTELY TRUE 1 2 3 4 5 NOT TRUE AT ALL					
09	When someone on my team asks "Why are we doing it this way?" my honest first reaction is defensiveness.	1	2	3	4	5
10	I have discouraged questions about decisions I've already made because I didn't want to reopen the discussion.	1	2	3	4	5
11	There are topics or decisions in my organization that people know not to ask about.	1	2	3	4	5
12	I have punished or sidelined someone - formally or informally - for asking too many questions or challenging the status quo.	1	2	3	4	5
13	I have pretended to solicit input from my team when the decision was already made.	1	2	3	4	5
14	I say I have an "open door policy" but there are things my people will not tell me. And I know it.	1	2	3	4	5
15	When presented with information that contradicts my position, my first instinct is to discredit the source rather than examine the information.	1	2	3	4	5

CURIOSITY SUBTOTAL _____ / 35

3 Challenge

Can people disagree with you?

	ABSOLUTELY TRUE 1 2 3 4 5 NOT TRUE AT ALL	
16	In my team meetings, disagreement is rare.	1 2 3 4 5
17	I have labeled someone as “not a team player” because they disagreed with me or pushed back on a decision.	1 2 3 4 5
18	I need to be seen as the person who came up with the idea, even when I didn’t.	1 2 3 4 5
19	I have made it clear - through words, tone, or consequences - that challenging my decisions is unwelcome.	1 2 3 4 5
20	The people in my inner circle usually agree with me.	1 2 3 4 5
21	When my team does disagree, I listen politely and then do what I was going to do anyway.	1 2 3 4 5
22	I have never asked my team “Tell me why this is a dumb idea.” Or if I have, I didn’t actually want to hear the answer.	1 2 3 4 5
23	The last time someone directly challenged me, it did not go well for them.	1 2 3 4 5

CHALLENGE SUBTOTAL _____ / 40

4 Trust

Would your people say you are straight with them?

	ABSOLUTELY TRUE 1 2 3 4 5 NOT TRUE AT ALL	
24	There are things happening in my organization that I am not transparent about, and my rationale for that secrecy would not survive honest scrutiny.	1 2 3 4 5
25	I have taken credit for work that was not mine, or allowed credit to be attributed to me without correcting it.	1 2 3 4 5
26	I have promoted someone who was not the most deserving candidate because of personal loyalty, political considerations, or convenience.	1 2 3 4 5
27	I have avoided giving someone honest feedback because I didn’t want to deal with the discomfort.	1 2 3 4 5
28	I have told my team one thing and my boss another about the same situation.	1 2 3 4 5
29	If my team could see every email I’ve sent and hear every conversation I’ve had about them, some of them would feel betrayed.	1 2 3 4 5
30	I have made promises to my team - about resources, support, recognition, or direction - that I did not keep, and I did not adequately explain why.	1 2 3 4 5

TRUST SUBTOTAL _____ / 35

5 Community

Do they work for each other, or for a paycheck?

	ABSOLUTELY TRUE 1 2 3 4 5 NOT TRUE AT ALL	
31	I have used the word “family” or “team” to describe my organization while behaving in ways that are fundamentally inconsistent with those words.	1 2 3 4 5
32	I have expected loyalty from my people without earning it through my own actions.	1 2 3 4 5
33	I have hosted team-building events or recognition programs while fundamental trust issues in my organization remain unaddressed.	1 2 3 4 5
34	My people would not say they feel genuinely valued by me.	1 2 3 4 5
35	If given the opportunity to leave with no consequences, a meaningful number of my team would do so.	1 2 3 4 5
36	I have laid off, reorganized, or made decisions that significantly impacted my people’s lives without being honest about the real reasons.	1 2 3 4 5
37	The bonds in my team exist in spite of my leadership, not because of it.	1 2 3 4 5

COMMUNITY SUBTOTAL _____ / 35

NOTES

Which statement was hardest to answer honestly? Start there.

SCORING

Add up your total.

Total score	
The sum of all thirty-seven statements. Lowest possible 37, highest possible 185.	_____ / 185

37–74

Your Lie Economy is thriving.

You are actively maintaining a culture where lies are the currency and truth is a liability. This is not a judgment of your character. It is a description of the system you have built and are maintaining. The good news is that systems can be changed.

75–111

You are living in the gray.

You know something is wrong. You can feel it. But you have rationalized enough of it to keep going. This is where most leaders live — aware enough to be uncomfortable, but not courageous enough to act. The danger of the gray is that it feels sustainable. It is not.

112–148

You are closer than you think.

You have the instincts, and maybe even some of the practices, of a Courage Economy leader. But there are gaps. And those gaps are where your Lie Economy lives.

149–185

You may already be building a Courage Economy.

But do not congratulate yourself yet. Take this assessment and then give it to your people. If their scores match yours, you are building something real. If their scores are significantly different, that gap is the most important data point you will get.

The gap is the point

The most valuable thing here is not your score. It is the gap between your score and your team's. That gap is the Lie Economy made visible — the distance between the story you tell yourself about your leadership and the truth your people live with every day.

If the gap is small, you have something to build on. If it is large, you have something to reckon with. Either way, now you know. And once you know, you can no longer pretend you don't know.

PILLAR	YOUR SCORE	THEIR SCORE	GAP
Important Work / 40			
Curiosity / 35			
Challenge / 40			
Trust / 35			
Community / 35			
Total / 185			

Adapted from *The Courage Economy* by Thane Bellomo — Chapter 16: The Lie Economy Audit.

Print a copy for each person on your team.